An Astronaut Spots 'Moon Rock' on Earth

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When you look at the Moon, you can see bright areas called **highlands**. Much of that brightness comes from a rock called **anorthosite**. Now an **astronaut** has taken a picture of a big patch of this rock on Earth.

On August 28, 2026, an **astronaut** on the International Space Station photographed it in southern Madagascar. Madagascar is an island country near Africa. From space, the rock looks like a bright circle. It covers about 40 square miles.

Anorthosite forms when melted rock cools slowly underground. That gives its **crystals** time to grow big. Scientists think this patch is at least 600 million years old.

Long ago, big pieces of land crashed together to make a giant **supercontinent** called Gondwana. The heat and pressure bent the rocks around this patch.

Studying Moon-like rocks on Earth can help scientists learn how the Moon formed.

Word Treasure

highlands -- High, bright areas on the Moon.

anorthosite -- A light-colored rock found on the Moon and in a few places on Earth.

astronaut -- A person trained to travel and work in space.

crystals -- Tiny solid shapes that grow inside rocks.

supercontinent -- A giant piece of land made when continents join together.

Background you need

The International Space Station is a science lab that circles Earth with astronauts inside.

Some rocks form when hot melted rock cools down and hardens.

Long ago, Earth's continents were joined in different ways than they are today.

Break it down

WHO: An astronaut on the International Space Station and scientists who study rocks
WHAT: A photo of a big patch of anorthosite, the same rock found on the Moon
WHERE: Southern Madagascar, an island country near Africa
WHY: Moon-like rocks on Earth can help scientists learn how the Moon formed

Why it matters

You can see the Moon's bright highlands at night, and rocks on Earth help explain what they are made of.

Test what you remember

1. What rock makes the Moon's highlands bright?

(A) Coal
(B) Anorthosite
(C) Sandstone
(D) Chalk

2. Where was the rock patch found?

(A) Canada
(B) The Moon
(C) Southern Madagascar
(D) Antarctica

3. Who took the picture?

(A) A kid with a phone
(B) A pilot in a plane
(C) A robot on Mars
(D) An astronaut on the International Space Station

4. How big is the rock patch?

(A) About 4 inches
(B) About 40 square miles
(C) As big as Africa
(D) About 1 mile

5. How old do scientists think the rock is?

(A) 10 years
(B) About 100 years
(C) At least 600 million years
(D) 1,000 years

6. What was Gondwana?

(A) A crystal
(B) A giant supercontinent
(C) A Moon rock
(D) A space station

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):